EXTENDING A HAND
Union home minister Amit Shah at a rally in J&K's Baramulla, (below) RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat delivering his customary Vijayadashami address in Nagpur, Oct. 5



MAHESH S TKLEY

"PEOPLE FEAR RSS MEN WILL BEAT THEM UP. SUCH MISINFORMATION HAS BEEN SPREAD. WE'VE BEEN MEETING MINORITY COMMUNITY MEMBERS TO ASSUAGE THEIR FEARS"

– MOHAN BHAGWAT, RSS *SARSANGHCHALAK*

deny saffron candidates a win. The loss of its old ally Janata Dal (United) in Bihar has also deprived the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance of a sizeable Muslim vote. The outreach, thus, is apparently an attempt to get a piece of the pie, even if the party leaders deny it.

Last month, in a first, the BJP-ruled Centre nominated a Gujjar Muslim—Ghulam Ali Khatana—to the Rajya Sabha from Jammu and Kashmir. In the Muslim-dominated J&K, Gujjars, Bakarwals and other marginalised sections often complain of Kashmiri Muslims getting disproportionate importance. BJP leaders claim they have adopted an "open-door policy" for dialogue with these tribal communities, whose influence extends to neighbouring Himachal Pradesh as well.

Prior to 2019, the BJP had arguably managed to make some headway in reaching out to liberal and moderate Muslims, by pushing a 'reform'-driven agenda. This included making triple talaq illegal shortly after coming to power, a subject of much controversy. But protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA)—within months of returning for